Singh, who was arrested in 2000. However, the then BJP president Kushabhau Thakre, facing large-scale public condemnation of the killings, issued a statement washing his hands of the controversy. Judeo was then forced to retract his statement.[75]

BJP state governments have long shared a close relationship with the ABVKA. Gujarat's minister for tribal development, for instance, attended the 8 May 2016 release of the organisation's 'Vision Statement', which called for increased government assistance to tribals to stop conversions. The minister, Mangubhai Patel, asserted, 'We led a revolution and today we can say for sure that conversion has stopped because of government's intervention.'[76]

Conversions are a fundamental concern for the wider Sangh Parivar as well. As senior pracharak Sunil Ambekar argued in his book, *The RSS: Roadmaps for the 21st Century*, 'What successive governments have acknowledged, the Sangh announced loudly. Conversion is a threat, particularly in tribal and underprivileged areas. The Sangh has expanded its footprint in these spheres. It is a high-priority focus. The Sangh runs a wide range of diverse programmes through its Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram.'[77]

This distrust of missionaries and framing them as anti-Indian is a trope that goes back to Golwalkar, who had argued in *A Bunch of Thoughts*, 'Their [Christians'] activities are not merely irreligious, they are also anti-national … So long as the Christians here indulge in such activities and consider themselves as agents of international movement for the spread of Christianity, and refuse to offer their first loyalty to the land of their birth … they will remain here as hostiles [sic] and will have to be treated as such.'[78] Yet, paradoxically, as we have seen, the Sangh emulated the growth strategies of the missionaries on education. Interestingly, Vidya Bharti stalwart and its then head, Lajjaram Tomar, told his national executive at Smriti Mandir in Nagpur in 2000 that they should appreciate the sacrifices made by the missionaries, not criticise them unnecessarily, and learn from their spirit and faith so 'that the enemies in the clashes of civilisation can be defeated'.[79]